

Two Weeks in Summer Soldiers and Others in Occupied Hesse-Kassel, 14–28 July 1625

War in History

1–25

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Abstract

The occupation of Hesse-Kassel during the Thirty Years War has been discussed by historians like John Thiebault. This paper revisits this topic with an analysis of letters exchanged between ordinary Hessian civilians and common cavalymen in the Liga army in July 1625. While this occupation was indeed a crisis, the relationships between these soldiers and other people were also ambivalent and contingent, including kinship. Since these relationships were inextricably enmeshed in the interactions between early-modern armies and their surroundings, this article discusses war and the environment. These letters help reveal early-modern military operations on the smallest scale.

Keywords

early modern, German history, social history, environmental history, Thirty Years War, economic history

The almost impossible quest to understand the intimate space that the human being puts between himself and his sense of self is the real work of the historian and, occasionally, when faced with this blank space which has to be unearthed and rediscovered, there is a strong temptation to let the documents from the...archives speak for themselves. Quite often they are so superb that one would like to give them to the reader as they are, without changing a single word; this is as much for their aesthetic value as for the depth of their significance.

—Arlette Farge, *Fragile Lives*¹

1 Arlette Farge, *Fragile Lives: Violence, Power, and Solidarity in Eighteenth-Century Paris* (Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press, 1993), 49.

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Introduction

On 21 July 1625 Hans Walther, saddler and messenger in the army of the Catholic Liga, took his last letters for delivery and headed northwest out of Schmalkalden.² He was intercepted near Kassel, with 27 letters in his satchel and a safe conduct pass from his colonel. The pass did nothing: Landgrave Moritz of Hesse-Kassel, the overlord of this place, was a devoted Calvinist and an enemy of the Holy Roman Emperor and Germany's Catholic powers. Walther's packet was confiscated and the city councils of Kassel and Schmalkalden examined the letters. Another messenger from the Liga army was intercepted near Allendorf on the Werra with 30 letters, heading from Eschwege in the same direction. These letters were taken too; the Hessian general auditor stored the two packets together, and they were eventually filed together.³

These were ephemeral documents, written by people of no importance and intended for people of no importance. They were preserved because these people happened to be connected to an army the Landgrave of Hesse-Kassel opposed. We cannot tell how many letters circulated among early seventeenth-century military communities and were not preserved.

As letters to and from common soldiers, these are among the oldest of their kind. Historians like Klaus Latzel, Ilya Berkovich, and Katrin and Sascha Moebius have analyzed eighteenth and early nineteenth-century military letters from the German-speaking world to explore topics like soldiers' view of death or their motivation to fight.⁴ Many of the ordinary writers in Martyn Lyons' analysis of letter writing were ordinary soldiers.⁵ But the correspondence of common soldiers during the Thirty Years War are more rare than these later examples.

John Thiebault and Quentin Outram analyzed the Liga occupation of Hesse-Kassel in the 1620s to assert that that central Europe suffered a massive mortality crisis during the Thirty Years War which was caused by the socio-economic relationships

2 Hessisches Staatsarchiv Marburg (HStAM) Best M 1 Nr. 725, 34.

3 Fritz Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe aus dem Dreißigjährigen Kriege. Selbstzeugnisse der kleinen Leute,' Walter Heinemeyer, ed., *Hundert Jahre Historische Kommission für Hessen 1897-1997, Vol I* (Marburg: Historische Kommission für Hessen 1997), pp.481-512; pp.485-487. Wolff called the letters in Walther's delivery the SMA series and the packet intercepted later the ESW series, and listed them as an appendix to his article. HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725 also contains documents which do not belong to either series like remarks made by the city councils and Hans Walther's deposition.

4 Klaus Latzel, "'Schlachtbank" oder "Feld der Ehre"? Der Beginn des Einstellungswandels gegenüber Krieg und Tod 1756-1815,' Wolfram Wette, ed., *Der Krieg des kleinen Mannes: eine Militärgeschichte von unten* (München: Piper Verlag, 1992), pp.76-92. Ilya Berkovich, *Motivation in War: The Experience of Common Soldiers in Old-Regime Europe* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017). Katrin and Sascha Moebius, *Prussian Army Soldiers and the Seven Years War: The Psychology of Honour* (London: Bloomsbury, 2019).

5 Martyn Lyons, *The Writing Culture of Ordinary People, C 1860-1920* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013).

between soldiers and other people, rather than the direct effects of combat or other violence.⁶ However, while the occupation of the Werra valley had a substantial impact, the letters in these caches show that the interactions between soldiers and others that took place during it were not solely negative. Relationships among soldiers and civilians during early-modern warfare were ambiguous and highly contingent. They were more ambivalent than a brutal dichotomy between occupier and occupied, and a wide range of possible relationships, actions, and responses to the actions of others was available. In demonstrating this complexity, this article is in keeping with recent microhistorical research into these interactions like that of Detlev Pleiss.⁷

Soldiers fought: one of the words they used for themselves was 'war people'. They dressed distinctively when they could afford it, and spoke distinctively. They formed a subculture and thought of themselves as such; from their own point of view they were superior to non-soldiers. But they were not separate from other people in the same way soldiers were in the following centuries.⁸ Specialized military housing was only barely beginning to be developed, and soldiers lived with non-soldiers. The people who sent and received these letters were roommates, best friends, casual acquaintances, potential business partners, and bitter enemies. They were relatives by blood or partnership: husbands and boyfriends (sometimes to more than one woman), wives and girlfriends, and in-laws. Close attention to the lived experiences of ordinary people is good to illuminate these relationships; so much about human interaction, especially the ambivalent, beautiful, or strange, turns on small details.

Armies in their Environment

The way soldiers interacted with one another and other people was inextricably enmeshed in the ways early-modern armies functioned within their surroundings, both the socio-economic relationships analyzed by Outram and soldiers' relationships

6 John Thiebault, 'The Rhetoric of Death and Destruction in the Thirty Years War,' *Journal of Social History*, 27.2 (1993). John Thiebault, *German Villages in Crisis: Rural Life in Hesse-Kassel and the Thirty Years' War, 1580-1720* (Leiden: Brill, 1997). Quentin Outram, 'The Socio-Economic Relations of Warfare and the Military Mortality Crises of the Thirty Years War,' *Medical History*, 45 (2001). Tryntje Helfferich, *The Iron Princess: Amalia Elizabeth and the Thirty Years War* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2013).

7 Michael Kaiser, 'Die Söldner und die Bevölkerung: Überlegung zu Konstituierung und Überwindung eines Lebensweltlichen Antagonismus,' Stefan Kroll and Kristen Krüger, ed., *Militär und ländliche Gesellschaft in der frühen Neuzeit* (Münster: LIT Verlag, 2000). Hans Medick, *Der Dreißigjährige Krieg: Zeugnisse vom Leben mit Gewalt* (Göttingen: Wallstein Verlag, 2018), Ch.III. Detlev Pleiss, *Bodenständige Bevölkerung und fremdes Kriegsvolk: Finnen in deutschen Quartieren 1630-1650* (Turku: Painosalama Oy, 2017).

8 Michael Kaiser and Peter Burschel make both these points. Michael Kaiser, 'Die Söldner und die Bevölkerung,' p.86.

to the land itself. In moving through and interacting with their environment, armies shaped it and were shaped by it.⁹ This environment was different from that of eighteenth or early nineteenth-century western European soldiers. There were fewer people: population density was low and by the middle of the decade almost every country's population had fallen.¹⁰ Agriculture was less productive, and food took more labour to produce.¹¹ Less land was cultivated; more was dominated by scrub, sand, or swamp. Rivers were unpredictable, shifting, and hard to navigate, their tracks were complex, and they were bordered by boggy low places.¹² But land transport was extensive even in winter.¹³ Early seventeenth-century roads may have been loose tangles of dirt tracks, but there were enough of them to move soldiers through this undisciplined landscape.¹⁴ Like military letters themselves, the roads over which the messengers who carried them rode were 'geographically extensive' but 'for the majority of the population un-systematised.'¹⁵

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- 9 For the ecological history of war see Hugh Clout, *After the Ruins: Restoring the Countryside of Northern France after the Great War* (Exeter: Exeter University Press, 1996). Harold Winters et al, *Battling the Elements: Weather and Terrain in the Conduct of War* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2001). Richard Tucker, ed., *Natural Enemy, Natural Ally: Toward an Environmental History of War* (Corvallis: Oregon State University Press, 2004). David Blackbourn, *The Conquest of Nature: Water, Landscape, and the Making of Modern Germany* (New York: WW Norton and Co, 2006). Chris Pearson, *Scarred Landscapes: War and Nature in Vichy France* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2008). Judith Bennett, *Natives and Exotics: World War II and Environment in the Southern Pacific* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2009). JR McNeill, *Mosquito Empires: Ecology and War in the Greater Caribbean, 1620-1914* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010). Lisa M. Brady, *War Upon the Land: Military Strategy and the Transformation of Southern Landscapes During the American Civil War* (Athens: Georgia University Press, 2012). Micah S Muscolino, *The Ecology of War in China: Henan Province, the Yellow River, and Beyond, 1938-1950* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015). A recent high-profile example is Geoffrey Parker, *Global Crisis: War, Climate Change, and Catastrophe in the Seventeenth Century* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013).
 - 10 For an overview of the seventeenth-century demography discussion see eg Anne EC McCants, 'Historical Demography and the Crisis of the Seventeenth Century,' *The Journal of Interdisciplinary History*, 40.2. (2009), pp.195-214.
 - 11 There is debate about when the 'second agricultural revolution' occurred. Mark Overton, *Agricultural Revolution in England: The Transformation of the Agrarian Economy, 1500-1800* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006).
 - 12 Blackbourn, *Conquest of Nature*, pp.3-7.
 - 13 JA Chartres, 'Road Carrying in England in the Seventeenth Century: Myth and Reality,' *The Economic History Review*, New Series, 30.1 (1977), pp.73-94
 - 14 Mark Brayshay, *Land Travel and Communications in Tudor and Stuart England: Achieving a Joined-up Realm* (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2014).
 - 15 James Daybell, *The Material Letter of Early Modern England: Manuscript Letters and the Culture and Practices of Letter-Writing, 1512-1635* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012), pp.111-113.

Relationships among military units and their environment influenced the strategic decisions officers took and the way units moved through the landscape.¹⁶ These armies were fragile, vulnerable to weather, food shortage, and disease. They moved slowly, spread out. Because the financial infrastructure of the political entities that employed them was still rudimentary and long-range transport could not fully supply task forces, soldiers frequently lacked supplies and pay. When companies could not house themselves off the local people and feed themselves off short-range transport and requisitions, campaigns foundered.¹⁷

The regiments represented in these letters were not only predatory forces moving through their environment, they engaged in complicated multi-way interactions with it to supply themselves.¹⁸ Civilian collaborators, more or less willing, participated in

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- 16 For seventeenth-century military supply, finance, and travel see Anton Ernstberger, 'Hans de Witte, Finanzmann Wallensteins,' *Vierteljahrschrift für Sozial- und Wirtschaftsgeschichte*, Special Edition Nr. 38 (Wiesbaden: Franz Steiner Verlag, 1954). Fritz Redlich, 'De Praeda Militari: Looting and Booty, 1500-1816,' *Vierteljahrschrift für Sozial- und Wirtschaftsgeschichte*, Special Edition Nr. 39 (Wiesbaden: Franz Steiner Verlag, 1956). Fritz Redlich, 'The German Military Enterpriser and his Work Force: A Study in European Economic and Social History' 2 vols, *Vierteljahrschrift für Sozial- und Wirtschaftsgeschichte*, Special Edition Nr. 48 (Wiesbaden: Franz Steiner Verlag, 1964-1965). Geza Perjés, 'Army Provisioning, Logistics and Strategy in the Second Half of the 17th Century,' *Acta Historica Academiae Scientiarum Hungaricae* XVI (1970). Geoffrey Parker, *The Army of Flanders and the Spanish Road 1567-1659: The Logistics of Spanish Victory and Defeat in the Low Countries' Wars* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1972). Martin van Creveld, *Supplying War: Logistics from Wallenstein to Patton* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1977). Bernhard Kroener, *Les Routes et les Étapes: Die Versorgung der französischen Armeen in Nordostfrankreich (1635-1661): Ein Beitrag zur Verwaltungsgeschichte des Ancien Régime* (Münster: Aschendorff Verlag, 1980). Jürgen Pohl, 'Die Profiantirung Der Keyserlichen Armaden Ahnbelangendt: Studien zur Versorgung der Kaiserlichen Armee 1635-36' (Horn/Vienna: F Berger & Söhne, 1994). John Lynn, *Giant of the Grand Siècle: The French Army, 1610-1715* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997). Derek Croxton, 'A Territorial Imperative? The Military Revolution, Strategy and Peacemaking in the Thirty Years War,' *War in History* 5 (3) (1998), 253-279. Erik A Lund, *War for the Every Day: Generals, Knowledge, and Warfare in Early Modern Europe, 1680-1740* (Westport: Greenwood Press, 1999). David Parrott, *Richelieu's Army: War, Government and Society in France, 1624-1642* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001). David Parrott, *The Business of War: Military Enterprise and Military Revolution in Early Modern Europe* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012). Lothar Höbelt, *Von Nördlingen bis Janckau: Kaiserliche Strategie und Kriegführung 1634-1645* (Vienna: Heeresgeschichtliches Museum, 2016).
 - 17 Robert Rebitsch, *Matthias Gallas (1588-1647), Generalleutnant des Kaisers zur Zeit des Dreissigjährigen Krieges: Eine militärische Biographie* (Münster: Aschendorff Verlag, 2006), pp.170-85. Lothar Höbelt, *Von Nördlingen bis Janckau*.
 - 18 Geoff Mortimer, *Eyewitness Accounts of the Thirty Years War 1618-1648* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2002), pp.49-50. Brian Sandberg, 'The Magazine of All Their Pillaging: Armies as Sites of Second-Hand Exchange during the French Wars of Religion,' Laurence Fontaine, ed., *Alternative Exchanges: Second-Hand Circulation from the Sixteenth Century to the Present* (New York: Berghahn Books, 2008).

these interactions.¹⁹ These expedients for survival were patchy and ad-hoc, like the 'economy of makeshifts' analyzed by historians of poverty among non-soldiers.²⁰ Here the lives of military women are especially visible. John Lynn called the shadow economy based around soldiers and their women the 'pillage economy': military women did a lot of work managing the flow of plundered or stolen goods.²¹

Tilly in Hesse-Kassel

The army of the Catholic Liga under Johann t'Serclaes, Count of Tilly, entered the small German political entity of Hesse-Kassel in early May, 1623. The soldiers 'came out' on 'Monday the 6 and 7 hujus and like smoke after the following days' wrote the local noble Dietrich Heinrich von Buttler on 10 July 1623: 'toward Ermschwerd [in Witzenhausen] and [Langenhain-] Ziegenberg, on the Usa and the Werra, to my cousin's and my brother's houses'.²² Tilly headed northwest, following the army of the hard-charging young anti-Imperialist general Christian of Brunswick. He returned late in 1623 and garrisoned Hesse-Kassel.²³

Politics inside the early-modern Holy Roman Empire were complicated. Hesse-Kassel and its neighbour Hesse-Darmstadt had been struggling for the remains of the landgraviate of Hesse, which was divided in 1567. When war broke out these political entities grafted their local dispute onto the general conflict: Moritz of Hesse-Kassel opposed the Holy Roman Emperor and the Catholic powers of Germany, but Ludwig of Hesse-Darmstadt was a staunch Imperialist. Meanwhile, the Estates of Hesse-Kassel were feuding with their own Landgrave and attempting to have him deposed; they supported the Imperialists and Hesse-Darmstadt. In 1624 the Estates allowed Tilly's troops free entry into the territory, and his army seized Schmalkalden and the southern half of Hesse-Kassel on behalf of Hesse-Darmstadt. The local nobility fled in 1626 and Landgrave Moritz's administration collapsed. Under pressure from his Estates and Tilly himself, he abdicated in 1627.²⁴

As of 1623 Tilly's troops were supplied with cash by Landgrave Moritz's administration and with cash, food, and goods by village authorities, at fixed rates. Although these demands for supplies were swingeing, they were regulated and predictable; according to

19 Mortimer, *Eyewitness Accounts*, Chap 4.

20 Alannah Tomkins and Steven King, ed, *The Poor in England, 1700-1900: An Economy of Makeshifts* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2003), p.1. The original formulation is Olwen Hufton, *The Poor of Eighteenth-Century France 1750-1789* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1974).

21 John Lynn, *Women, Armies, and Warfare in Early Modern Europe* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008), p.8 passim.

22 HStAM Fonds 340 von Buttler Nr. 429, *Acta die Kriegslasten und Einquartierungen in dreissigjährigen Kriege betreffend, anno 1623+1624-45, 1631, 1758-1762, 1822*. Rough draft of letter from Dietrich von Buttler to Tilly, 10 Jul 1623, p.10r.

23 Antoine Charles de Villermont, *Tilly, ou, La Guerre de Trente Ans* vol 1 (Paris: Casterman, 1860), p.254.

24 Thiebault, 'The Rhetoric of Death and Destruction,' p.279. Helfferich, *Iron Princess*, pp.21-26. Thiebault, *German Villages in Crisis*, Ch.5.

Thiebault this occupation was largely peaceful at that time.²⁵ But the soldiers plundered as they moved through Hesse-Kassel: von Buttler wrote that the men who came into his lands like smoke withdrew ‘them not alone, but much cattle, fruit, meat, beer, and other things, for instance all bedding, linen; household goods of iron, copper, and tin.’²⁶ Thiebault says these acts were merely instrumental, but soldiers stole von Buttler’s books, and he spent a lot of time trying to get them back. By 1626, Tilly mentioned ‘the distress and poverty of the currently exhausted and worn down lands’. The village of Grandedorn reported 187 burials that year.²⁷

When the Kassel authorities snatched Hans Walther, the woman with him, and their child servant in summer 1625, they panicked. The Hessian general auditor and the city councils of Kassel and Schmalkalden were stoutly loyal to Landgrave Moritz--and threatened by Hesse-Darmstadt, their own subjects, Tilly’s occupying army, and Hesse-Kassel’s rebellious Estates.²⁸ The general auditor had questions. Who were the recruiters for Denmark and Ernst von Mansfeld? How much did Tilly’s troops know about the Hessian militia? Did money change hands between the locals and Tilly’s soldiers? Did the locals wish any of these soldiers good luck in an upcoming battle, or regret their misfortune in an earlier one? He was especially interested in illicit contact between Tilly’s soldiers and the upright citizens’ daughters of Hesse-Kassel, and examined letters for ‘punishable lewd things’ involving women. The city councils threatened to punish the women involved for adultery and lewdness, and to flog and exile anyone who gave up military secrets. Hans Walther and the woman with him were questioned. Walther was tortured.²⁹ He testified or was made to testify that he ‘received [letters] from citizens, citizens’ daughters, and young women, and wanted to bring them into Tilly’s camp.’³⁰

The members of the military community who wrote or received the letters in these packets were all connected to Tilly’s cavalry: troopers, cavalymen’s servants (*Knechte* or *Jungen*), saddlers or armourers, and women who travelled with armies. Most were part of Colonel Otto Friedrich von Schönberg’s regiment, many in his personal company. When this regiment moved into the area its companies settled northwest of Marburg in Kirchhain, Rauschenberg, Willingshausen, Schwarzenborn, Bad Zwesten, Jesberg, Fritzlar, and Treysa.³¹ Figure 1 maps the locations of the companies in the Schönberg regiment as of August 1623, and of the Liga cavalry regiments around them. These companies were deliberately distributed, each in its own roughly delineated area.

At some point between August 1623 and July 1625 the companies in the Schönberg regiment shifted into the region around Eschwege and Schmalkalden. Walther’s letters were primarily written in the single town of Schmalkalden, while his colleague’s letters were written in more broadly spread-out locations around the Werra region: each messenger may have had a beat.

25 Thiebault, *German Villages in Crisis*, p.141.

26 HStAM Fonds 340 von Buttler Nr. 429 p.10r.

27 Outram, ‘Socio-Economic Relations,’ p.179-180.

28 Wolff, ‘Feldpostbriefe,’ p.485.

29 Wolff, ‘Feldpostbriefe,’ pp.485-486.

30 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, 34.

31 HStAM Fonds 340 von Buttler Nr. 429, p.25.

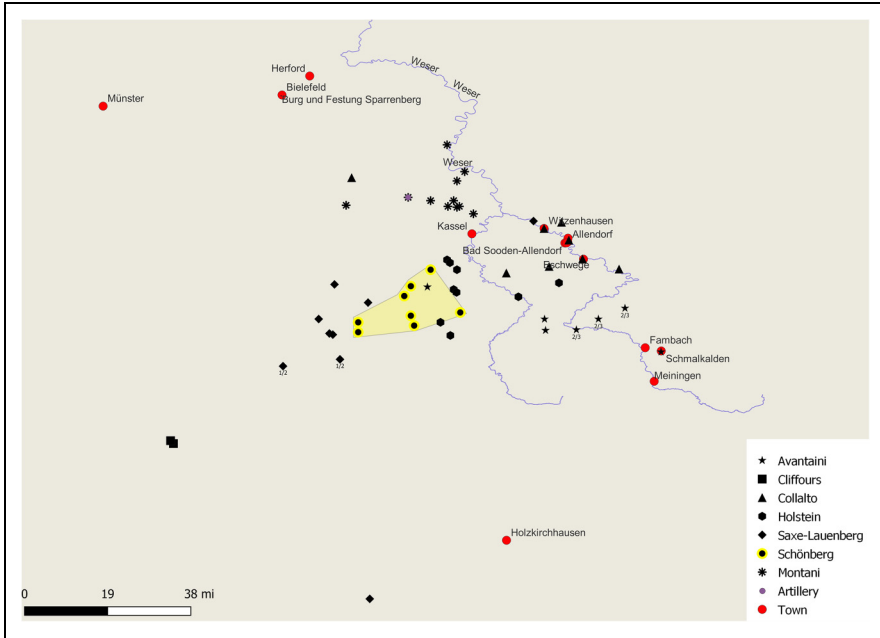


Figure 1. Known Locations of Companies in von Schönberg's Regiment, Known Locations of Companies in Regiments Montani, Avantaini, Collalto, Holstein, Saxe-Lauenberg, Clifours, and the artillery. Von Schönberg emphasized. HStAM Fonds 340 von Buttler Nr. 429.

According to Wolff this regiment's advance into Hesse-Kassel in 1623 was accompanied by plundering and abuse, but these letters do not depict what happens when an alien force invades a region: by mid-July 1625 these regiments had been quartered in Hesse-Kassel for more than two years.³² Many of these cavalrymen were men from these towns who had enlisted during that time. Early seventeenth-century military units recruited constantly, since their numbers constantly seeped away as soldiers died, deserted, or got sick--mostly deserted.³³ These units were continually shedding soldiers and continually recruiting; armies often operated in a particular area over a long time and sucked up recruits while they did. Soldiers and military women could end up serving near their homes after they joined the local occupying army. Many early seventeenth-century soldiers came from the places where they fought, or made ties where their armies sent them.

The cavalryman Hans Mohs, his *Jung* Martin Hartmann, and another soldier named Bartholt Kellner exchanged letters with Hans's 'heart's love' Catherina Hartmann, her father, and their entire household from their 'field camp near Bielefeld, on the trench-side.' Martin Hartmann was probably Hans Mohs's younger brother-in-law. Catherina wrote a letter to Hans on her own but signed it 'Catherina and Ursula

³² Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.484.

³³ Parrott, *Richelieu's Army*, p.178.

Hartmann'--Hans and Catherina's relationship was everyone's concern.³⁴ Like everyone else Catherina called von Schönberg's personal company the 'Allendorf company': it had moved into Allendorf, and local people had joined it. They moved on when their companies moved on, like Martin Hartmann. In his deposition Hans Walther said that he collected letters from 'some newly-enlisted soldiers from Schmalkalden.'³⁵ But these were still Liga regiments, and they had operated in French-speaking areas as well as alongside the Spanish army. A few soldiers had French names, like Lavare, who had been shot. A man from eastern Europe, known as Sabbatkeciv, received greetings from his friends.³⁶ One letter was addressed to 'Joseph the Spaniard'; Wenzel Schneider's daughter had married a Spaniard, who was in Schmalkalden again.³⁷

Letters to and from residents of the Werra valley and troopers like Sabbatkeciv and Joseph the Spaniard demonstrate that the popular interpretation of the 'absence of significant bonds of kinship, language, nationality or, often, ethnicity between civilians and the soldiers in their midst' as an exacerbating factor in early-modern military atrocities may need to be revised.³⁸ Even the soldiers in the Werra valley who were not related by blood to its non-military inhabitants, or not German at all, were no longer strangers to those on whom they were quartered after two years in the same bed and at the same table. This long term intimacy contained every human emotion.

The physical environment and human context within which armies operated shaped the way soldiers related to other people, and the way contemporaries conceptualized these relationships. Early seventeenth-century members of the military community were in closer contact, and in contact more often, with other people than later troops. 'I beg you diligently not to forget me, your child asks after you a lot, I want you to know your man is at my next door neighbour's place again, and I wish much good to you and your corporal, as God wills', one nameless woman wrote her daughter.³⁹

Soldiers practised a distinctive way of life, but the boundaries between this community and other people were unclear and not fixed: 'I beg you for God's sake come back home with the messenger,' wrote an anonymous man to Hans Heinrich Marold, 'your kinsman Hans Steinbitt didn't mean it when he said you were a scoundrel, won't you at least go to Kassel to your suckling child Liese, but if you want to be a man of war [*Kriegs Knecht*, respectful address for soldier], your kinsman Veit Schippel would like a *Jung*.'⁴⁰ The concept of the 'civilian,' which united everyone who was not a soldier in the same

34 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 12, ESW 13, ESW 14, ESW 15.

35 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, 34. Deposition neither ESW nor SMA.

36 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 8, SMA 9. Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.490.

37 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 15. Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.490. HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 1.

38 Outram, 'Socio-Economic Relations,' pp.179-180.

39 'dersalben bitt ich dich gantz Vleißig du Wollest mich nihc laß\, dein kindt hart sehr nach dir, thun dir hermit Zu Wißen dz dein Man wie derrumnb bei meiner nechsten nachbar scheit, Vnd Wunsch dir Vndt deinem Corpral Viel guts hiermit Gott bevohlen,' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 20.

40 'Ich bitt dich vmb Gottes willen gehe mit dem botten wied/ Zu hauß, dein Vetter hanß Steinbitt daß hett er nicht gemeint daß du Zum schelmen solst werd\, Wiltu aber nicht so gehe doch nach Caßell Zu deiner Banß Liesen, Wiltu aber ein Kriegs Knecht sein, So will dein Vetter Veit Schippell gern ein Jungen haben,' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 19.

category, may not yet have existed. Legal theory and the customs of war said certain groups of people should not be harmed.⁴¹ Supplicants may not be killed said Grotius, nor children, women as long as they do not fight, priests, monks and penitents, people pursuing science and useful arts, farmers, merchants, prisoners of war, those who surrender with terms or without, and hostages.⁴² Ferdinand II called the people his soldiers were not supposed to molest his 'poor subjects' or 'the guiltless poor common man'.⁴³ That these people are 'guiltless' or 'innocent', that unlike soldiers they 'do not harm' (*non nocere*) is a precursor of the concept of the civilian.⁴⁴ But to my knowledge there was no single word for 'non-soldier'. When 'Zivilist' was first attested in German a hundred years later in 1718, it meant expert in the civil law.⁴⁵ Early seventeenth-century central European society was composed of many social orders (*Stände*), and soldiers were one of them.⁴⁶

The Letters

The 55 letters and fragments in these packets comprise subjects like God, health and sickness, friendship, enmity, love relationships, kinship, parents and children, travel, battle, equipping and provisioning, money, death, plunder, doggerel, jokes, magic, and peace.⁴⁷ The dated letters were written between 14 July and 28 July 1625. The latest ones Hans Walther carried were written the day he left Schmalkalden, 21 July: Hans Rem Jr interrupted the letter he was writing to his younger kinsman (*Schwager*) Johann Reichart to say Walther was at the door. They walked around town together sharing news, then Rem wrote another letter and gave Walther both.⁴⁸

41 Geoffrey Best, *Humanity in Warfare: The Modern History of the International Law of Armed Conflicts* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1980). Richard Shelly Hartigan, *The Forgotten Victim: A History of the Civilian* (Chicago: Precedent Publishing, 1982). Geoffrey Best, *War and Law Since 1945* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1994), Ch.2. Alexander Downes, *Targeting Civilians in War* (Cornell: Cornell University Press, 2004). Hugo Slim, *Killing Civilians: Method, Madness, and Morality in War* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2008).

42 *De Jure Bellum ac Pacis*, Bk.II, Ch.11.

43 Saxon State Archives Dresden (SHStADr) 10024 9239/5 p.67v.

44 Colm McKeogh, *Innocent Civilians: The Morality of Killing in War* (Basingstoke: Pgrave Macmillan, 2002).

45 *Deutsches Wörterbuch von Jacob Grimm und Wilhelm Grimm*, 'Zivilist A.'

46 Peter Wilson, 'Was the Thirty Years War a Total War?' Erica Charters, Eve Rosenhaft, and Hannah Smith, ed., *Civilians and War in Europe, 1618-1815* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), p.32.

47 These categories are rough. Mention of God, 47. Health or illness/injury, 41. Previous or ongoing exchange of letters, 35. Previous or ongoing interaction, 30. Friendship, 29. Love relationships, 28. Kinship, 26. Adult children and parents/guardians, 23. Letter written by group, 20. Letter addressed to group, 14. Travel, 12. Rumor and hearsay, 12. Minor children and parents/guardian, 11. Political or military division / battle, 10. Economic exchange/ money, 10. Provisioning, 9. Honor and manliness, 8. Enmity, 7. Equipping, 6. Death, 5. Plunder, 5. Interactions with/well wishes to officers, 4. Doggerel, 4. Drawings, 3. Jokes, 2. Magic, 1. Peace, 1.

48 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 1, SMA 2.

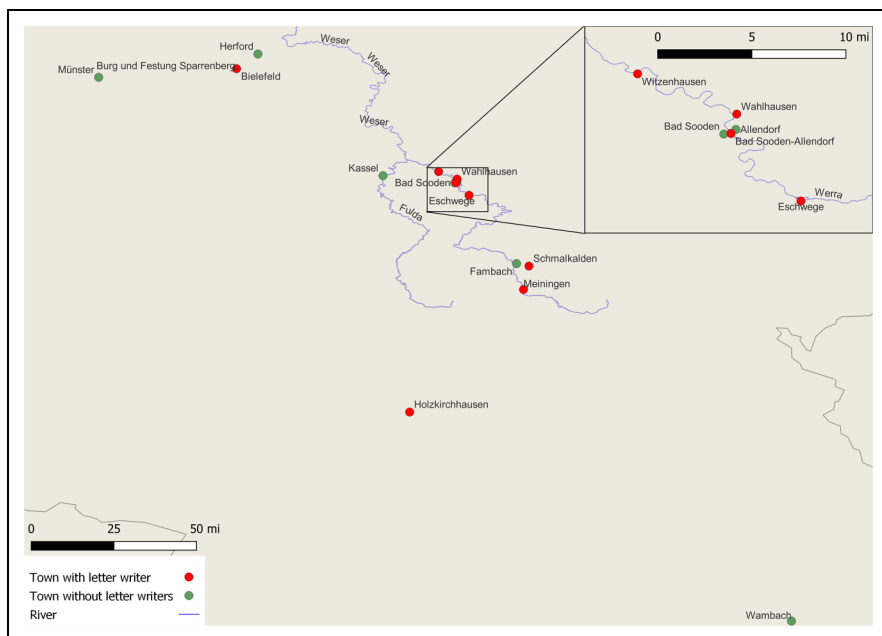


Figure 2. Known Locations of Writers and Recipients of Letters in HStAM Best M I Nr. 725 from 14 June to 28 June 1625, Members of the Military Community and Civilians.

Figure 2 maps the locations of authors and intended recipients in mid-June 1625.

At least 108 people were involved with these letters as senders or intended recipients. The precise number is impossible to determine since letter-writing was communal: when ‘Valtinus Peter and all his friends’ at home, ‘especially Eva and Margaret,’ wrote a letter to the soldiers ‘big and little George,’ the number of friends is unclear.⁴⁹ Roughly half of them, 51, were members of the military community, as opposed to 57 civilians. More civilians were writers and more soldiers were recipients: Hans Walther had finished passing out letters from soldiers and was on his way to deliver the replies when he was captured. Most of the civilians lived in specified locations: 51 out of 57 had a known location (89%), as opposed to 23 members of the military community out of 51 (45%). This discrepancy may have been because these regiments were mobile: if someone addressed a letter to a soldier’s last known address he may not have been there by the time it arrived, or his location may not have been known to his relatives and friends. It could also have been because Hans Walther and the other messengers knew where everyone in von Schönberg’s regiment was already, and did not need it written down.

Six letter-writers in Schmalkalden were farriers, saddlers, and bakers; five were cobblers, wagoners, and day labourers. Hans Rem Jr was a steel merchant, probably a big one; ironmongers and spur-makers also wrote letters. Some letter-writers specified

⁴⁹ HStAM Best M I Nr. 725, SMA 25.

their occupations, like Jost Sigmund Rummel the baker. There were citizens and hand-workers, citizens' daughters and serving maids. One girl was a goldsmith's daughter.⁵⁰ Mechior Schellenberger, city record-keeper (*Stadtschreiber*), exchanged letters with Johannes Mösel, muster-writer in the Wahl regiment: one was a soldier and one was not, but their jobs were similar, and they addressed each other as kinsmen.⁵¹

Whatever their estate, the people who produced and interacted with these letters were used to the written word. Many analyses of early-modern letters and writing focus on the elite; James Daybell claims that although writing spread down the social scale in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, it was not until the eighteenth century that letter writing took on a more democratic form.⁵² Yet literacy in the seventeenth-century Empire was comparatively high, and the military community was probably more defined by paper messaging than most. Literacy among German-speaking cavalymen during the Thirty Years War may have been as high as eighty percent--although the sample in the study which argued this was a socially elite group of men, and may not have been representative.⁵³ People of many estates either read and wrote or associated with people who could: written culture influenced the lives even of people who could not read.⁵⁴ At least two letter-writers in Eschwege may have bought papers with the salutations already written, in stout, elaborate--and obviously practiced--calligraphy that filled the entire top of the page.⁵⁵ (Unfortunately only half these letters are autographs; the Kassel council had the letters in Hans Walther's packet recopied.⁵⁶)

Some people who sent or received the letters in these packets were illiterate, and their letters were written by others. Claus Gorge was a citizen of Allendorf and his son Becker was a soldier; Becker's friend Johannes Sbrickel, also a soldier, was close to the Gorge family. Becker Gorge wrote to his father himself: he wanted him to hold his letter in his hands when he got it, and wished everyone 'all good and a happy morning'.⁵⁷ When Claus responded, it was to Sbrickel: a man named Hans Brand did the writing in a barely-grammatical scrawl and told a man named Hanne Pfetter to read it out loud to Sbrickel.⁵⁸ Writing and reading letters were group activities.⁵⁹

Antagonism

Hostility between soldiers and non-soldiers is a more familiar element of early-modern warfare than cooperation. Soldiers plundered and killed civilians and civilians fought

50 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' pp.491-492.

51 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 18.

52 Daybell, *The Material Letter*, p.20.

53 Lucian Staiano-Daniels, 'Scribes and Soldiers: A Brief Introduction to Seventeenth-Century Military Manuscripts,' *Manuscript Studies* 5.1 (2021), p.160.

54 Adam Fox, *Oral and Literate Culture in England, 1500-1700* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), p.8.

55 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 4, ESW 5.

56 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.488.

57 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 10.

58 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 11.

59 Daybell, *The Material Letter*, pp.9-10, 13.

back. According to Thiebault, villagers responded to the occupation of the Werra valley with passive acceptance from 1623 to 1625 because to openly attack soldiers would have been suicidal.⁶⁰ However, these letters reveal low-level chronic violence: although the balance of power between Tilly's army as a whole and the residents of the Werra valley was as one-sided as Thiebault argued, non-soldiers attacked these letter-writers when they found them alone.

As Catherina Füllgrabe left a village near Allendorf 'I was attacked by some peasants but when I went back into the village I hired a peasant's wife who went with me happily to Allendorf'.⁶¹ When Maria Brauns got her letter from Hans Thomas 'it was completely open. The messenger told me the Hessian peasants had attacked him and had come to him, and had taken all the letters from him [*undt hatten ihm die schreiben im allen dahin geschodt*], once they saw he was a messenger they gave him all the letters back.' Even so Maria's original letter was lost. The cavalry arranged another messenger for her, which implies a proactive messenger system.⁶²

The locals tempered their hostility to members of the military community with desire for money, respect for a messenger's position, or the familiarity of long habitation side by side. Sometimes it was just hostility. While she was waiting for her letter Maria Brauns fought with the young people around town who wanted to know what she was doing with a cavalryman, and she fought with a woman named Anna Borggräfin. Maria called Anna 'the black Borggräfin'. 'There is no more self-righteous young lady than Anna Borggräfin. She says she would rather see a dog in the street than a cavalryman.'⁶³

But this is described from outside; it is Maria Brauns who is writing because she's close to Hans Thomas, or she wants to be. Borggräfin did not write to a cavalryman herself to express her contempt for, and fear of, the profession. One year later, soldiers killed four civilians in Gradeborn, which had not happened before.⁶⁴ In contrast, because these letters were exchanged among people who knew one another already, the most bitter anger in them is personal.

An anonymous man in Schmalkalden wrote to his soldier brother-in-law Johannes Klein. 'Dear kinsman [*gevatter*]' he said. 'What do I hear that you have been routed, and that you sent my poor sister and your child away?' Rumour of a battle and a defeat had gone around Schmalkalden; more letter-writers from that town repeat it, fewer from the Werra valley in general. 'How can your heart be pure? Do you think people don't know you ran all around the city to go courting in a pleasure garden? If you wanted you should have sent her home again: we could have fed your child and her.' The writer seems to have been terrified for his sister, which by the middle of the letter turned to anger against the man he blamed for her situation. 'Such a false heart I had not thought to find in you. The Schmalkalders are upright people but I don't trust you. But if you want [a woman] so fast, you would better have done one of the fenceposts that lie behind the city walls, and not have turned [my sister] into a common whore with

60 Thiebault, *German Villages in Crisis*, p.143.

61 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 8. Page mislabelled as 28 and filed after ESW 27.

62 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 22.

63 *Ibid.* 'Es ist kein Keüsher Jungfr' als Anna Borggräfin, Sie spricht, sie will lieber ein shaff-hundt sehen, alß einen reütter...'

64 Outram, 'Socio-Economic Relations,' pp.178-179.

such a friendship.' He was consumed with rage more bitter for its impotence, in this life if not the next: 'Finally it'll go like this. At the Last Judgement I will scream *ee, ee* over you. As God wills. PS: You asked my mother why she looked at you the way she did. She said when she was with you last she wanted to tell you who you were.'⁶⁵

Surely civilians lived differently from members of the military community: by the end of the letter this writer was convinced life with Johannes Klein dishonoured his sister sexually. But these resentments are personal, not general, memories of specific interactions at specific times: this anonymous man's mother's choked silence, Johannes Klein and his female companion courting in the garden.

Social Networks and the Lives of Women

Soldiers and non-soldiers formed and maintained social networks we can see through these letters. As soon as Jost Sigmund Rummel, baker and citizen of Schmalkalden, got a letter from Peter Blanschon, one of von Schönberg's cavalymen, he responded. He greeted Peter's 'entire Corporalschaft, the people you are quartered on, and your two cousins, as well as your wife and children.'⁶⁶ (A corporalschaft is a smaller unit within a company, led by a corporal.) Blanschon had passed through Schmalkalden with a crowd. The letters went back and forth: Valtin Huttenrodt of Eschwege was responding to an earlier letter that Bernhard Müller, the soldier who had been quartered on him, 'done wrote to' him (*ihr an vns gethan geschrieben*). He called Müller his 'beloved son' and wanted to know when he could see Müller again as well as Müller's female partner (*mit Consorten*), 'who is very dear to me and my wife'. 'Please greet all the righteous soldiers for me, namely: Martin Reising and his Gretin [Margaret], and Michael the Monk'.⁶⁷ His words echoed the military lingo of the soldiers who had stayed in his house.

Franz Melbach's vocabulary has a similar military tincture. The cavalryman Peter Klein had been quartered on Melbach and by July 1625 they were close: Melbach called Klein 'brother.' Melbach also used military lingo; certainly he knew a lot of cavalymen. 'It is my wish that you greet the honourable and manly Captain Georg Jagenhirsch from me, and ask him where the *verehrte* horse is that I should fetch.' He signed off: 'To Peter Klein, George Jagenhirsch, Long Adam, Donkey Chris, and all

65 'Mein lieber h\l gevatter, Waß hört Ich das ihr so verzagt seidt, Vndt habt meine Arme schwester Vnndt Ewer Kindt Verschenkett, Wie Kan Ewer hertz reine sein, Meinet ihr dz man nicht Wiße dz ihr in der gantzen Stadt herumb gelauffen seidt Auch in Lustgarten Zufreyen, Wen ihr dz gesinnet weret gewest, soltet ihr Zie wieder heimb geschickt haben, So hatten wir Ewer kindt undt Sie Können ernehren, Ein solch falsch hertz hette ich bei Euch nicht gesucht, Ob schon die Schmalkälder *brave* leütte so trawe Ich Euch doch nicht Zu, Wen ihr aber eine nitt lenger hett haben wollen, So hette darZu Wohl gethan eine hinder den Zeünen die hinder der Statt mawer liegt, Vndt nicht in einer solchen freundschaft eine gemeine dim Zu machen, es doch Zu letzt nicht anders geht, so Will ich am Jüngsten gericht über Euch Jeder J J schreien, hiemitt Gott befohlen. Am nehern habt ihr mein Mutter geßagt, wofür Sie Euch ansehe, So sagt Sie, wan ihr ietz bei ihr weret, so wolte Sie euch sagen Wer Ihr Wehrt, Nochmals Gott beVohlen.' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 7.

66 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 27.

67 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 5.

the righteous guys who ask after me, you are and should be saluted and greeted by me and our entire household.' Soldiers called themselves righteous guys, *rechtschaffene kerlis*. Franz Melbach knew his old roommates, these soldiers: he knew how they talked. He knew what was important to them: 'And when you get fresh bread, then think also on me.'⁶⁸

Verehrte means revered, but when a mercenary said it, it meant given as payback for a debt. This implies an ongoing reciprocal relationship among Melbach, Klein, and Klein's captain. It would be facile to assume from a single letter that this relationship was one only of trust and friendship; at this moment Melbach writes like he was happy to fetch a horse for Jagenhirsch, but we do not know how this enterprise turned out. But 35 of these letters mention previous letters, and 30 mention previous interaction like speaking in person or visiting someone's house: they are single elements of repeated exchanges.

Women are prominent as participants in the low-level scraping for provender demonstrated in these letter collections. When Ottilie Künken and Lorenz Schreiner wrote to the cavalryman Jacobus Lanbir, Ottilie said she remembered Jacobus all the time, 'especially when I think about your red mouth,' but Lorenz wrote his PS in the margin: 'It's Lorenz, who made your knives. I hope you can grab enough grub where you are, because you sure didn't lack for it in Schmalkalden! To the writer of this a tip and a rabbit--to the reader some dirt on his big long nose.' It rhymes in German.⁶⁹ Lorenz was probably Ottilie's kin. Margareta Klemper was close to Niclas Denchler and wrote him a letter after he left Schmalkalden: she thought he would send her something by the messenger 'out of love', but he didn't. Because Niclas didn't pay for his wine on the way out, the woman Margareta was staying with ripped Margareta's cloak off her neck. On the back page of her letter she says another Klemper made Niclas's cuirass.⁷⁰ Schmalkalden was known for its steel goods.⁷¹

Women are also visible in their innocent expressions of desire, like Ottilie's thoughts about Jacobus Lanbir's red mouth. Hans Thomas was getting letters from three women at once.⁷² He was the cornet of von Schönberg's personal company, the flag-bearer, which when the men were fed and supplied was a swaggering office, with boots and ringlets and jingling spurs. One woman introduced him to her sister.⁷³ The Kassel and Schmalkalden city councils conceptualized these documents as 'love letters', which is the name under which they were filed.⁷⁴ Soldiers and the women with them did not live with each other the way male and female civilians did; people who were unconnected to the military community could perceive this as licentious. Historians who focus on Italy found a similar

68 'Vnndt sey du peter klein, Jorge Jagenhirsch, der lange Adam, Christoffell Esel, vnd alle rechtschaffene kerlis die nach mihr fragen, sein und sollen, Von mihr un unsern gantzen hausgesinge *Salutiret* vndt pegrussen, Vndt Wen ihr frische brutt bekommet, so dencket an mich auch.' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 4.

69 'Ich Lorentz der dir die meßer gemacht hatt Wünsht dir daß du Zu futter gnug kriegest, den du Zu Schmalkald\ keinen mangell dran gehabt hast, Den schreiber ein drackgeltt Vndt ein hasen, den Leser ein dreck auf die große langt nasen.' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 11.

70 'Ferner sollt ihr Wißen Niclaß von wege\ deß Klemperers der Euch den Kuraß gemacht hatt...' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 13.

71 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.501.

72 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 3, SMA 22, SMA 28.

73 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 28.

74 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' pp.487-488.

fear of social contagion from soldiers; in that case, a religious threat from soldiers who were not Catholic.⁷⁵

Historians like John Lynn argue that gender relations within military communities operated within a socio-economic context in which womens' tasks were essential for units to function.⁷⁶ In her analysis of women in the Swedish army, Mary Elizabeth Ailes concurs with these observations while delineating womens' actions on campaign. Military women also provided emotional and material support to one another.⁷⁷ Jennine Hurl-Eamon analyzed the living strategies of the wives of soldiers and sailors in eighteenth-century England, who augmented military pay by stealing, accepting aid from others, pawning goods, and taking odd jobs.⁷⁸

The women who travelled with early seventeenth-century armies resorted to similar makeshift expedients to live and keep their men alive, which these letters demonstrate on an individual basis. Catherine Neusessen wrote one of the letters in this cache to her sister Irmgard when she lost her job on the local lord's estate: 'therefore I have to want you to send me some plunder, because you should have plenty'.⁷⁹

The Limits of Division

As Tilly and other Imperial-aligned generals manoeuvred against Christian of Brunswick, Ernst von Mansfeld, and the Danish army, both sides recruited in Hesse. One woman who wrote Hans Thomas told him the Landgrave of Hesse-Kassel was arming his militia and the king of Denmark was recruiting, but 'in secret'.⁸⁰ Since armies' zones of control outside their immediate networks of communication was ephemeral to nonexistent, they did this in proximity to one other.

Hessian or wider political divisions contributed to the varied loyalties of some families in these letters, especially the wealthy. These loyalties were expressed locally, even dividing families; they could also be somewhat casual. Hans Rem Jr was a steel merchant in Schmalkalden. He may have been older than soldiers like his kinsman Johann Reichart; it was not his friends who were joining up but their children. 'On 12 July Jörg Kößel from [Hans] Jäger's house wrote to me and then he came here, he was carrying your pistols.' Kößel told Rem 'his father should pay you for our weapons, and he said on the 15 July he had to go out, he had a horse worth 24 Reichsthaler, he had not ridden it more than a day, his father would have to buy him another'.⁸¹ But by the time Rem wrote his second letter Hans Jäger's parents had 'very cruelly and dreadfully' treated him and Kößel. The two young men ended up enlisting in the anti-Imperialist Danish

75 Sabina Loriga, *Soldats: Un laboratoire disciplinaire : l'armée piémontaise au XVIII siècle* (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 2007). Daphne Lappa, 'Religious Conversions within the Venetian Military Milieu (17th and 18th Centuries),' *Studi Veneziani* (2014).

76 Barton Hacker, 'Women and Military Institutions in Early Modern Europe: A Reconnaissance,' *Signs* 6.4 (1981). Lynn, *Women, Armies, and Warfare*.

77 Mary Elizabeth Ailes, *Courage and Grief: Women and Sweden's Thirty Years War* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2018), Ch.2.

78 Jennine Hurl-Eamon, 'The fiction of female dependence and the makeshift economy of soldiers, sailors, and their wives in eighteenth-century London,' *Labor History*, 49:4 (2008).

79 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 21.

80 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 3.

81 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 1.

army on their own; Jörg still had Johann Reichart's pistols.⁸² These letters do not record whether he or his father ever paid for them. Of the people Rem knew in Schmalkalden, 'Heinrich Schreiber's enlisted with the king of Denmark, he's a senior squad leader, Antjen Schoner's son's becoming a Mansfelder, he's an infantry flag bearer, Hans Franckenberger's son is a senior squad leader, he's enlisted with the Mansfelder.' Both the king of Denmark and Ernst von Mansfeld led anti-Imperialist armies in the area. 'Veit Schippel is also out, he's also an infantry flag-bearer, Wenzel Schneider's *Eidan* [servant or son in law] the Spaniard is still here...'⁸³ (Schippel was Hans Heinrich Marold's kinsman, mentioned in another letter.) Rem's friends' children were mostly fighting for anti-Imperialist armies while his kinsman Reichart fought for Tilly, which means they might also have been loyal to the Landgrave while Rem and Reichart might have favoured the Estates. Hans Jäger's parents may have gotten angry at him and Jörg Kößel because they wanted to enlist in the Danish army.⁸⁴

The men and women who exchanged these letters were similarly casual about confessional difference. Religion was one of several factors in the outbreak and course of this war.⁸⁵ Confessional conflict was a central cause of the war in Hesse, and data from sources Thiebault examined reveal that division between Calvinists and Lutherans was central to civilian village life in the Werra valley.⁸⁶ However, although many of the soldiers in the Liga army were presumably Catholic, little that is denominationally specific appears in these letters.⁸⁷ Almost all letter-writers mention God or pray for safety and good health, but these statements are general to many Christian confessions. Members of the military community may have been more likely to 'go along to get along' with comrades of other confessions, since seventeenth-century armies were multi-religious.⁸⁸

Georg Schmidt argues that by the end of the Thirty Years War, the concept of God lost its this-worldly power.⁸⁹ I believe this is too strong a thesis: Amalia Elizabeth, eventual Landgravine of Hesse-Kassel, was motivated by her Calvinist faith. But in most of these letters her future subjects and the soldiers with whom they associate withdraw, not from God, but from explicit denominational specificity. Catherina Hoscharin was married to Peter Hoschar; when she gave birth to a little girl, the baby's godfather Jacob Zielfelder prayed that God would give parents and child his holy blessing.⁹⁰ Hoschar

82 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 2.

83 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 1.

84 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 2. This is Wolff's inference: 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.491.

85 Peter Wilson, 'Dynasty, Constitution, and Confession: The Role of Religion in the Thirty Years War,' *The International History Review* 30.3 (2008). Peter Wilson, *The Thirty Years War: Europe's Tragedy* (Cambridge MA: Belknap, 2009). Herfried Münkler, *Der Dreißigjährige Krieg: Europäische Katastrophe, deutsches Trauma 1618–1648* (Reinbek: Rowohlt 2017). Johannes Burkhardt, *Der Krieg der Kriege. Eine neue Geschichte des Dreißigjährigen Krieges* (Stuttgart, Klett-Cotta 2018). Georg Schmidt, *Die Reiter der Apokalypse: Geschichte des Dreißigjährigen Krieges* (Munich: Beck 2018).

86 Thiebault, *German Villages in Crisis*, Ch.1.

87 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' pp.503-504.

88 Michael Kaiser, 'Cujus exercitus, ejus religio? Konfession und Heerwesen imZeitalter des Dreißigjährigen Krieges,' *Archiv für Reformationsgeschichte* 91 (2000).

89 Schmidt, *Die Reiter der Apokalypse*, p.645.

90 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 16.

was French, like his friends; Catherina wrote that she wanted to speak to him about their visit to France, and her mother eventually went there.⁹¹ Catherina and her large, affectionate family wrote to him and prayed for him; although I suspect they were Protestant, I do not know either her or his confession.

Enemy armies lay close together, scattered, like a handful of barley and a handful of rye across a table. Catherina Hoscharin was in Schmalkalden; Catherina Zielfelderin took the baby to Heiligenstadt; Peter Hoschar was in Allendorf. When Catherina Hoscharin wrote that she had a child, she also said her brother, 'our Valtin', and her kinsman's stepson had enlisted with the anti-Imperialist colonel Knyphausen and were in Münden. Hoschar's brother in law was his enemy: if he falls into your hands give him quarter.⁹² Valtin was quartered 22 miles away from his enemy and brother-in-law in Allendorf, 14 miles down the Fulda from Kassel. Münden controlled the strategically important junction where the Fulda and the Werra joined and became the Weser: in June 1626 Tilly's army, Schönberg's regiment included, stormed the city and massacred about one thousand inhabitants and most of the garrison.⁹³

Overshadowed by the later sack of Magdeburg under the same commander, the sack of Münden was still vicious.⁹⁴ Wilson maintains that this brutality arose from specific circumstances like the defenders' refusal to surrender rather than confessional antagonism.⁹⁵ Commentators apparently did not give it a wider religious significance at the time, which Medick argues may have been one reason this massacre never truly broke out of the less-well-known history of the war; unlike Magdeburg, it was not presented as a 'martyrdom' of Protestants.⁹⁶ These arguments are corroborated by these affinal ties between defenders and at least one attacker.

This fluid and partite situation was characteristic of many areas of life, not just combat. Historians of early-modern Europe who analyze confessionalization, law, criminality, and social disciplining have moved from portraying these topics in terms of top-down control to emphasizing the ways in which subordinate groups actively navigated their social world.⁹⁷ In many cases seemingly draconian laws were not

91 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 17.

92 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 17, p.61v.

93 Wilson, 'The Role of Religion,' p.490.

94 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.505. Thomas Kossert, 'Die Eroberung der Stadt Münden 1626,' MA Thesis University of Freiburg (2007). Hans Medick, *Der Dreißigjährige Krieg: Zeugnisse vom Leben mit Gewalt* (Göttingen: Wallstein Verlag, 2018), pp.205-207.

95 Wilson, 'The Role of Religion,' p.490.

96 Medick, *Der Dreißigjährige Krieg*, pp.211-215.

97 Gerhard Oestreich, *Neostoicism and the Early Modern State* (Cambridge: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1982). R. Po-Chia Hsia, *Social Discipline in the Reformation: Central Europe 1550-1750* (New York: Routledge, 1992). Gerd Schwerhoff, 'Devianz in der alteuropäischen Gesellschaft, Umriss einer historischen Kriminalforschung', *Zeitschrift für historische Forschung*, 19 (1992). See also Achim Landwehr, *Policey im Alltag: Die Implementation frühneuzeitlicher Policeyordnungen in Leonberg* (Vittorio Klostermann: Frankfurt am Main, 1999). Philip Gorski, *The Disciplinary Revolution: Calvinism and the Rise of the State in Early Modern Europe* (Chicago: The Univ. Of Chicago Press, 2001). Andre Wakefield, *The Disordered Police State: German Cameralism as Science and Practice* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2009).

carried out.⁹⁸ To this we can add the reinterpretation of social disciplining in armies by historians like Peter Wilson and David Parrott.⁹⁹ The limited power of authorities in all these spheres is in part a result of this human relationship to the environment: authorities like Colonel von Schönberg—or Catherina Hoscharin's pastor—relied on the cooperation of their subordinates because it was so difficult to enact their wills over distance without it. Their subordinates, meanwhile, mediated their religious identity or military allegiance through local relationships with people and things including kinship, physical proximity, relationships with terrain, and access to resources. This resulted in similar patterns of action to combatants in modern conflicts such as those in Syria and Iraq.¹⁰⁰

Maintaining Relationships Over Distance

But the Schönberg regiment and its component elements maintained command and control through the circulation of documents and messengers.

The relationships among Franz Melbach, Peter Klein, and Captain Georg Jagenhirsch involved numerous soldiers and civilians and may have spanned hundreds of miles: Melbach lived in Eschwege but the location of Jagenhirsch and his men was not recorded. Similar distances are apparent in the relationship among Michael Graft, his female companion Anna, and the man they had been quartered on. Michael, staying in Allendorf, wrote to Anna, staying in Fambach, on their host's behalf: 'Dear treasure I ask you to fetch 500 horseshoe nails to my host in Schmalkalden, and then he will have them sent to me by this messenger because the messenger will come back to us in three weeks.'¹⁰¹ Fambach was about two hours' walk from Schmalkalden. 'Also ask my host about the deerhide and whether it is ready.'

Figures 3 and 4 divide the data in Figure 2, mapping civilians with known locations between 14 July and 28 July 1625 (Figure 3) and soldiers with known locations at the same time (Figure 4).

Seventy two people represented in these letters had known locations, exactly two thirds of the 108 people involved with these documents. Of this 72, 22 were members of the military community and 50 were civilians. Because of the nature of the relationships this article covers, who was a 'civilian' and who was attached to Tilly's cavalry is difficult to pin down. For the purposes of these maps someone is a member of the military community if they are living with the army when they write their letter; Catherine

98 Jürgen Schlumbohm, "Gesetze, die nicht durchgesetzt werden: ein Strukturmerkmal des frühneuzeitlichen Staates?" *Geschichte und Gesellschaft* 23.4 (1997).

99 David Parrott, *Richelieu's Army: War, Government, and Society in France 1624-1642* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006). Peter Wilson, 'Early Modern Military Justice', Davide Maffi ed, *Tra marte e astrea. Giustizia e giurisdizione militare nell'Europa della prima età moderna (secc. XVI-XVIII)* (Milan: FrancoAngeli, 2012), pp.43-86.

100 Mary Kaldor, *New and Old Wars. Organized Violence in a Global Era* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 3ed 2012). Münkler, *Der Dreißigjährige Krieg*. Lucian Staiano-Daniels, 'America Doesn't Control the Forever Wars: The slow fall of the nation-state's monopoly on violence will shape future conflicts,' *Foreign Policy* (2022).

101 'und mir bei dießen botten dan er in dreien woche\ wiederumb Zur uns kommen wirdt schicken thun.' HStAM Best M I Nr. 725, SMA 5.

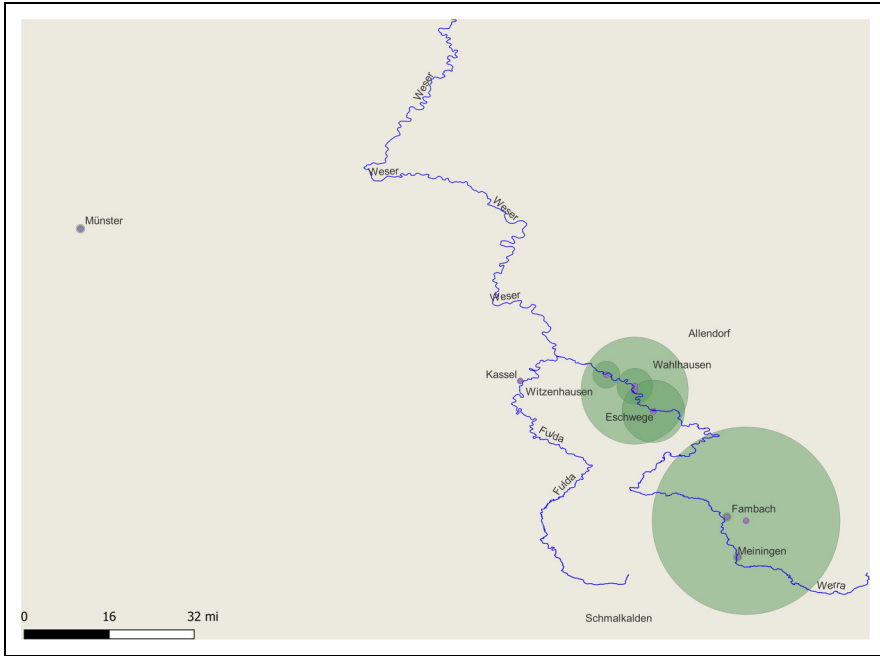


Figure 3. Known Locations of Civilians who Sent or Received Letters in HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725.

Neusessen is counted in Figure 2 and Irmgard Neusessen in Figure 3, although they are sisters.

On 12 June 1625 Tilly broke camp. He crossed the Weser, then came to Bielefeld and took it, and made it his headquarters.¹⁰² The sprawling composite entity that was his army moved slowly, and its many elements did not travel to the same place at the same time. We see traces of its movement in these maps.

The civilians in Figure 3 were primarily clustered around Schmalkalden and Allendorf. Out of 50 civilians with known locations from roughly southeast to northwest, 1 was in Holzkirchhausen, 1 in Meiningen, 21 in Schmalkalden, 1 in Fambach, 7 in Eschwege, 12 in Allendorf, 3 in Witzenhausen, and 4 in Walhausen. (Holzkirchhausen, which is far away, does not appear in Figure 3.) Some of these towns were conveniently located next to one another, in clusters: although Schmalkalden and Allendorf were about fifty miles apart, Fambach and Meiningen were five and fifteen miles away from Schmalkalden and Eschwege and Witzenhausen were each nine miles from Allendorf.

Between 14 June and 28 July the members of the military community in Figure 3 were scattered across a similarly great expanse of territory. Bielefeld was Tilly's base of operations; one letter to Hans Mohs and his companions was addressed to 'a field camp near Bielefeld on the trench-side.'¹⁰³ But only 4 members of the military community in these

102 de Villermont, *Tilly*, p.297.

103 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 12.

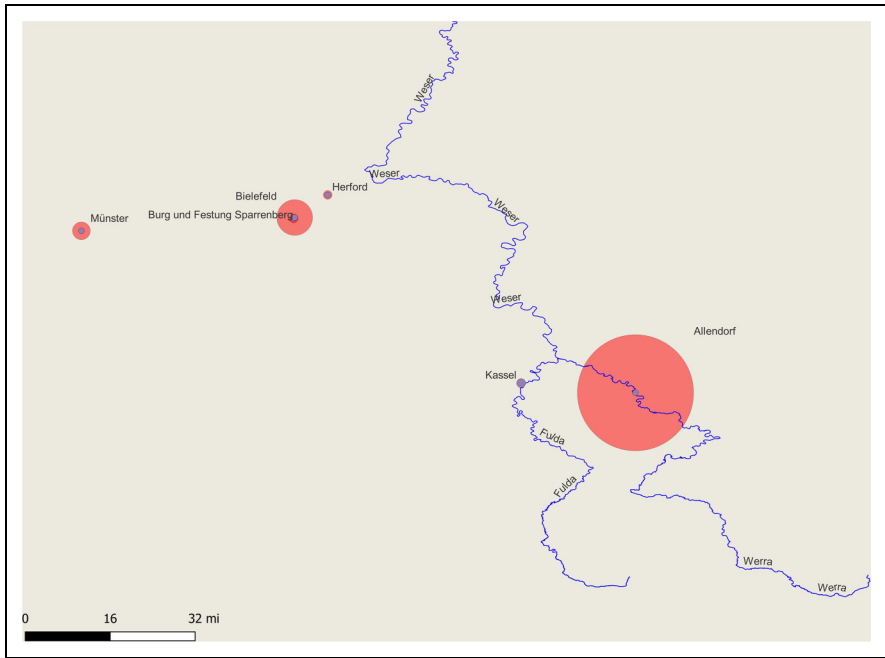


Figure 4. Known Locations of Members of the Military Community who Sent or Received Letters in HStAM Best M I Nr. 725.

letters were lodged around Bielefeld itself, as well as 1 in nearby Sparrenburg and 1 in Herford. Most of them, 13 people, were still staying in Allendorf. Two cavalrymen could have gone anywhere: a letter to Andreas Viereck and Jacobus was marked ‘ask for them in the territory [*Stift*] of Münster.’ The city of Münster was about 40 miles due west of Bielefeld, but the Prince-Bishopric of Münster owned territory in the vicinity of Hesse-Kassel.¹⁰⁴ One may have been in Wambach, far to the south. (Wambach may also have been a spelling error for Fambach,) Wambach does not appear on Figure 3.

The two-week snapshot created by this data catches Tilly’s army in the process of moving northwest to threaten Christian of Brunswick, who had just taken Höxter, and prevent him from joining forces with the King of Denmark.¹⁰⁵ Some soldiers moved out of Schmalkalden abruptly: several letter-writers in that town said they left too soon to say goodbye. When Tilly started moving his army fanned out and moved toward Bielefeld, but not all at once: the fuzzy flashlight beam of their location shifted from a centre in Schmalkalden to a centre in Allendorf. Current locations of civilians represent past locations of members of the military community.

Studded with mills and dams, the Werra was not passable to ships above Wanfried, seven miles upriver from Eschwege, but below Wanfried ships went up and down

¹⁰⁴ HStAM Best M I Nr. 725, SMA 4.

¹⁰⁵ de Villermont, *Tilly*, p.297.

frequently. Most boats on the Werra and Fulda were light; in early twentieth-century photographs their pilots stand in them and pole them along.¹⁰⁶ Timber rafts travelled down both rivers, and woad from Thuringia down the Werra; linen manufacture used the water to prepare flax. These horsemen would have gone north beside the river down roads without a name, loose braids of dirt track, and down the river on small boats. Johann Christian Castenbein and his daughter Barbara wrote to Ehrat Kramer, 'Got the news how bad it goes with you, you get a pound of bread a day and must beg so far as the water runs.'¹⁰⁷

From Eschwege to Münden the biggest tracks were more often orthogonal to the Werra than parallel to it, which is probably one reason why Hans Walther was intercepted in Kassel.¹⁰⁸ Leaving Witzenhausen he probably headed south and west to Kassel on the biggest and easiest route, and from there would have headed to Bielefeld. Towns were small: according to contemporary censuses, Schmalkalden had about 900 households, Eschwege had 730, Allendorf had 460, and Witzenhausen had 340. The inhabitants of these towns numbered about 5000 people at the highest to 1800 at the lowest.¹⁰⁹ In late nineteenth and early twentieth century photographs these places are tiny. Whether personal relationships between individual soldiers and individual civilians were well-willing or not, it was hard for these little communities to support incoming members of the military community and their demands. To travel, to feed, and to trade, armies spread out, probably by squads or corporalschafts, even individual men. Like smoke, said Dietrich Heinrich von Buttlar.

These were tiny forces operating over great distances. The total distance from Herford to Meinigen was about 150 miles and on paper Otto Friedrich von Schönberg's regiment had eight companies and three hundred riders.¹¹⁰ Yet across these distances von Schönberg tried to maintain administrative control over his regiment. He issued Hans Walther his safe-conduct pass in Allendorf, 95 miles from the trenches outside Bielefeld and his own commanding officer.¹¹¹ When Walther was captured he was on his way back to Bielefeld and Herford, near the southeastern end of a great circuit.

Messengers like Hans Walther and the woman and child with him must have gone back and forth regularly among these outspread cavalymen. Catherina Füllgrabe was a military woman who was staying with her in-laws in Allendorf and writing to her husband Nicholas Kasseler. She said her in-laws were suspicious of her: they 'took a distrust of me' and thought 'I might leave my man [you] without honour'. They were happier once she let them read her letters. Catherina's PS was to her kinsman Heinrich Kasseler:

106 Manfred Lückert, *Die Werra: Landschaft und Leben am Fluß zwischen Thüringer Wald und Hann Münden* (Bad Langensalza: Verlag Rockstuhl, 2006).

107 'Uns Die bot schafft wie es euch so Ubel ginge griegest einen tag ein Pfunt brot Unnd muss bet so weit euch Dem wasser lauffen.' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 16.

108 Armin Weber and Willi Görich, 'Landstraßen 16.-18. Jahrhundert,' *Geschichtlicher Atlas von Hessen* (Frankfurt aM, 1960), Karte 29a.

109 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' p.503.

110 HStAM Fonds 340 von Buttlar Nr. 429, 25, Johann Konrad Geisthirt, 'Historia Schmalkaldica,' *Zeitschrift des Vereins für Hennebergische Geschichte und Landeskunde* IV Supplement (Schmalkalden and Leipzig, 1883), p.36.

111 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 24.

'I've had no messenger from you for 14 days'.¹¹² If late messengers were worth complaining about, they may usually have been less late. Sometimes the delays had a reason: when Hans Rem Jr signed off on his letter to Johann Reichart he said 'The messenger remains away next Saturday, we've heard it from his wife, because this one has been killed and has died.'¹¹³ Hans Walther was not dead: he had just arrived to take Rem's letters and may have been standing at the door while Rem sat to write: more than one messenger had been shuttling back and forth among these people. These messengers maintained a schedule. They provided regular service, they remembered their clients personally, and their clients tipped them.¹¹⁴ 'I did not refrain from writing to all of you, because a messenger has come in here, and he is loaded with cargo,' wrote Hans Mohs.¹¹⁵

This must have taken a lot of work. Rem's letters are preoccupied with the difficult and dangerous business of travelling to meet his military kinsman. 'Dear *Schwager* Johannes, I have from the messenger, and also understood from your letter, that you would have well seen me come to you all and that we could ride home together' but that was impossible now:

I have bought 8 hundredweight of steel, and next Monday, the 25th July, I'm going to Hamburg with my cousin Jacob, if this were not the case, that I had not bought the steel, then I would have left it pending [*lassen anstehen*] and would have come to you, but I hope in 3 or 4 weeks, I will be home again, and the messenger could come here again, if you want that from me, then I will come to you.¹¹⁶

From Schmalkalden to Hamburg was 225 miles. Rem wrote about the distance between him and Reichart and the safety of his proposed journeys. 'We told Boll you were going to ride to near Frankfurt' said his second letter: 'He could have done the same but he already had another thing to do, and I want to go to Hamburg with... Jacob, but when he comes back home, and if you are around there still, if he could come there safely, I would let that happen.'¹¹⁷ Margareta Klemper wanted to follow Niclas Denchler from Schmalkalden to wherever he had ended up but was afraid she wouldn't make it alone. 'If you have the opportunity to come to Schmalkalden again, I would gladly march out [*ziehen*] with you.'¹¹⁸

While the soldiers in the Schönberg, Wahl, and Truchsess regiments stayed in the Werra valley they made connections with the local civilians. When locals joined these regiments they retained their connections with the people around them. When Tilly's army moved on its horsemen left these connections behind, and maintained them. This communication took place neither through official diplomatic channels nor the post.¹¹⁹

112 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 8 in Wolff's list, labelled 28.

113 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 2.

114 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 1, ESW 5.

115 'dan Ih than Nit Vntter lassen Euch Zuschrieben, weil Ein bodt harin gedt, Vnd haben Eingelegenen laadenn,' HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, ESW 12.

116 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 1.

117 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 2.

118 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 13.

119 Joad Raymond and Noah Moxham, ed. *News Networks in Early Modern Europe* (Leiden: Brill, 2016).

Compare Hans Mohs, Martin Hartmann, Catherina Hartmann and their thicket of local connections to Joseph the Spaniard, whose only letter was from a woman who did not record her location at the time but who signed off as Margaret from Mossbach, which is in Thuringia—both members of that couple had originally been outsiders.¹²⁰ On the other hand, some letter-writers, like Catherina Füllgrabe, seem to have been writing to people in the same towns where they stayed, instead of or in addition to speaking face to face. We usually associate letter-writing this intensive by ordinary people with the nineteenth century.

Conclusion

‘When you write here again,’ said Hans Rem Jr to Johann Reichart, ‘you will order the messenger to be careful of your letter and not get it stuck to the other ones.’¹²¹ Round red wax seals sticking papers together; canvas satchel in the sun, late June—letters were not the only vehicle the common soldiers and ordinary people in the Werra valley had for communicating with one another, but they are one of the few we can see.

This article uses letters carried by cavalry messengers in the Liga army under the Count of Tilly during its occupation of Hesse-Kassel to tease out some of the complex interactions among soldiers and other people in the early seventeenth century, and to argue that it may be inappropriate to frame these interactions with the simple dichotomy of ‘soldiers and civilians’. These human relationships took form within the interactions of armies with their material surroundings, from the struggle to supply oneself to command and control through challenging territory.

In arguing that interactions among soldiers and civilians were ambivalent, this article corroborates recent microhistorical analyses of the Thirty Years War. These analyses are unified by what Hans Medick described as the coexistence of ‘violence and living together’, or ‘the everyday and catastrophe’: the experience of the Thirty Years War within individual dwellings encompassed all the small activities of daily life as well as violence.¹²² However, the violence Medick described is between soldiers and those upon whom they were quartered, while the violence in these letters is committed by people uninvolved in their writing or delivery. The interactions depicted in these letters show another facet to the relationships among soldiers and others: for since the regiments in the Werra valley had been stationed there for two years, many of the people who exchanged these letters were related by blood, if local men joined up, or by marriage/partnership, if soldiers formed ties with the families among which they lived. In depicting the interactions of people who know one another already, this group of letters offers a perspective on the experience of early-modern European warfare that historians do not often study.

These interactions were only sometimes directly threatening. But they occurred in the presence of threat: local non-soldiers, political opponents, the rumour of battle. Peter Hoschar’s relatives were stationed in the garrison at Münden, and were probably

120 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 15.

121 HStAM Best M 1 Nr. 725, SMA 2.

122 Hans Medick and Benigna von Krusenstjern, *Zwischen Alltag und Katastrophe: der Dreissigjährige Krieg aus der Nähe* (Leiden: Brill, 2001). Medick, *Der Dreißigjährige Krieg*, Ch.III.

slaughtered there. These glimpses of potential violence within families or within groups of people who knew one another are characteristic of the domestications of conflict in civil wars.

These letters express their writers' thoughts simply; the effect is flat as a woodcut. They demonstrate not only the complex and effortful networks of writing required for even one company to maintain cohesion in the field and awareness of its surroundings, but also that unknown people were powerful writers and speakers. They have great aesthetic value, and evoke in me a piercing wistfulness.

At the end of August 1625, one month after Hans Walther was apprehended and tortured, he reappears in the historical record: the Schmalkalden district magistrate, Urban von Boineburg, was paying him to carry messages. Urban himself was allied to the anti-Imperialist, pro-Landgrave administration of Hesse-Kassel; his family was so anti-Imperialist they had stockpiled weapons in Moritz's support in 1622.¹²³ When the Landgrave was forced to abdicate he was fired too and replaced with a member of the Wersabe family, a relative of Anna Wersabe, who wrote to Hans Thomas panicking for his safety. But despite Urban's loyalties, the von Boineburgs were one of a group of Hessian families who negotiated with Tilly in 1624. Although Urban von Boineburg was loyal enough to Landgrave Moritz to be removed with him, his connections may have led him to protect Hans Walther and give him a job.¹²⁴ So Hans Walther became a messenger again.

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123 Thiebault, *German Villages in Crisis*, p.137.

124 Wolff, 'Feldpostbriefe,' pp.486-7.